

GAMING AGAINST THE ODDS

PAYAL DHARE'S JOURNEY INTO THE SPOTLIGHT

"My journey started in a very organic way. Growing up in a small town, gaming was not seen as a career option, especially for girls," says Payal Dhare. What began with simply watching cousins play evolved into experimenting with YouTube in 2019, sparked by PUBG Mobile. Early streams with just a handful of viewers felt significant, hinting at something bigger. Over time, that small beginning grew into a strong, supportive community — turning curiosity into a full-fledged career.

What's unique about your content?

I would describe my content as a mix of gaming, real-life moments, and a lot of unfiltered personality. Gaming is at the core, especially titles like BGMI, but what makes

it really unique is how interactive and personal it feels. I have always focused on building a space where people feel like they are a part of the whole experience, and not just watching it. Whether it is live chats, conversations during streams, or sharing parts of my life outside of just gaming, there is a strong sense of connection with the audience. That relatability, especially coming from a small-town background, really resonates with people.

Most misunderstood thing about being a creator?

A lot of people think it is just about playing games and having fun, but there is much more happening behind the scenes. Content creation requires consistency, planning, and constant evolution. There is also an emotional side to it. Being constantly visible means you receive both genuine appreciation and unsolicited noise. As a female creator, I have learned to navigate outdated stereotypes and criticism, which takes focus and resilience that often goes unnoticed behind the scenes.

Are you driven by a specific mission in what you do?

One of my biggest motivations has

been to break gender stereotypes and make gaming more inclusive, especially for girls. Coming from a background where gaming was never encouraged as a career, I understand how difficult it can be to even consider it as an option or an opportunity. If my journey can inspire someone to take that first step, that is something I value a lot. Over time, I have seen that impact grow through my community and the kind of messages I receive from them. Being part of important conversations around gaming in India has also shown me how far the industry has come.

What advice would you give to aspiring content creators in India?

Start without waiting for the perfect moment. I started with basic setups and just experimented. What matters most is consistency and the constant willingness to learn. Do not get discouraged by slow growth in the beginning. Building something meaningful takes time. Focus on improving your content and connecting with your audience. Most importantly, be yourself. Your individuality is what will help you stand out. **d**